

Hypothesis and Imagination Series ①

8. Wonhyo's Theory of Hwajaeng and the Principles of a Symbiotic Economy

Human Survival Strategy through Correlative Thinking and Hwajaeng in the AI Era · Choi Won-hyeok

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This chapter explores how the structure of the Buddhist Four-Gate (Sammun) Hwajaeng examined in Chapter 5 can be applied to the economic problems of today.

8.1. The Historical Development of Hwajaeng Theory

Wonhyo's thought of Hwajaeng was systematized in the Simmun hwajaeng-non (Treatise on the Reconciliation of Disputes in Ten Aspects, 十門和諍論). It is a principle that acknowledges the partial truth held by each position while integrating them within a more comprehensive truth.

Two-term Hwajaeng corresponds to the stereoscopic thinking (Mimesis) of Part 1. Three-term Hwajaeng corresponds to the cyclical thinking (Mythos) of Part 1. Four-term Hwajaeng structurally corresponds to the four modes of correlative thinking in Part 1—Ipche (stereoscopic), Sunhwan (cyclical), Gonggam (empathy), and Yunghap (convergence).

8.2. The Hwajaeng Structure of Economic Theory

The economic problems humanity faces today are likewise ultimately structured as a four-term relation of four economic theories. Each of these schools of thought offers a different answer to the question "What is justice?", yet seen through the lens of Hwajaeng they are mutually complementary as segments (harmony, 和) of the whole cycle.

The following table shows the relationship between traditional economic theories and the Four-Gate Hwajaeng.

Table 9: The Relationship between Traditional Economic Theories and the Four-Gate Hwajaeng

School of Thought	Core Principle	Four Gates	Season	Philosophical Core
Utilitarianism	The greatest happiness of the greatest number (efficiency)	Arising-and-Ceasing Gate (Saengmyeol-mun)	Spring	The autonomous arising (起) of the seed—the eruption of individual vitality
Communitarianism	Shared values and social bonds	Three-Natures Gate (Samseong-mun)	Summer	The efficient expansion of the receptacle-world (器)—maximizing phenomenal abundance
Social Contractarianism	Rational procedure and fair agreement	Suchness Gate (Jinyeo-mun)	Autumn	Cessation into fair rules—universal order and principle
Libertarianism	The individual's absolute right of ownership and freedom	Pure Land Gate (Jeongto-mun)	Winter	The faith-arising (信) of the great vessel called "we"—fundamental solidarity and the One Mind

These four economic theories correspond precisely to the four-seasons cyclical principle of Hwajaeng. Freedom (spring): the economy begins only when individual creativity springs forth. Efficiency (summer): resources must be allocated

efficiently so that society as a whole grows abundant. Fairness (autumn): transparent rules are needed to resolve conflicts over distribution. Solidarity (winter): at the end of the whole process there must be the communal repose of "we are one."

Furthermore, the correspondences with Eastern thought stand out. If the "principle (li, 理)" of Neo-Confucianism is the fairness of social contractarianism, then the "compassion" of Buddhism is the warmth of communitarianism, and the "wu-wei (non-action)" of Daoism is the noninterfering vitality of libertarianism.

8.3. Economic Hwajaeng Seen through Vessel (器) and Arising (起)

The conflicts of the modern economy fundamentally stem from the difference between valuing the "vessel (器, institutions and structures)" and valuing "arising (起, creative energy)." Only when the mutual complementarity of these two concepts is understood from the perspective of Hwajaeng can the opposition among economic theories be resolved.

[Utilitarianism (Arising/起 of spring)] "It is good to enlarge the size of the pie held in the vessel as a whole." It emphasizes outcome-centered efficiency.

[Communitarianism (Vessel/器 of summer)] "We are not isolated vessels. Only within the great vessel (器) of community does the individual's life meaningfully arise (起)." It emphasizes the human being as a correlative existence.

[Social Contractarianism (Cessation/rules of autumn)] "A transparent contract (cessation) that everyone can accept, no matter who becomes the owner of the vessel, must come first." It seeks the legitimacy of procedure.

[Libertarianism (Faith-arising/信 of winter)] "Let not the vessel (the receptacle-world) arbitrarily infringe upon the achievements (起) I have won." It gives top priority to the individual's creative energy.

8.4. The Expansion of Hwajaeng and the Symbiotic Economy

The AI era makes the need for Hwajaeng more urgent than any age in history. The modern economy, immersed solely in the infinite expansion of "spring (utilitarianism)," has lost its "winter (the repose of libertarian freedom)." AI maximizes the speed of this summer and thereby alienates human beings.

The direction of a Hwajaeng-based resolution is as follows. First, acknowledge community (summer) while making it known that community arose from individual freedom (winter). Second, pursue efficiency (summer) while keeping it within the framework of a fair contract (autumn). Third, through Hwajaeng grounded in symmetry (對稱性), pursue a structure that acknowledges the validity of each theory while integrating them cyclically. Fourth, the hyperconnective technology of the AI era becomes the material foundation of Hwajaeng-based connection.

Only when we understand that the economy is not a set of static numbers but a "time of water" that circulates like the four seasons does sustainable peace arrive. When the four great engines of freedom, efficiency, fairness, and solidarity are integrated into a single One-Mind (一心) economic model, the economy of the AI era is transformed into a symbiotic economy (相生經濟).

8.5. The Hwajaeng of World Religions

The Great Master Wonhyo's Hwajaeng (和諍) is a universal meta-model applicable not only to conflicts within Buddhism but also to oppositions among the world's religions. In particular, the three Abrahamic religions—Judaism, Christianity, and Islam—set out from a single root yet have clashed fiercely throughout history. Seen through the lens of Hwajaeng, they share the same essence (nature, 性) while colliding in phenomena (appearance, 相).

From a Hwajaeng perspective, these three religions are not mistaken about one another; rather, they are correlative manifestations in which a single divinity (the One Mind) has revealed itself according to different epochal demands within the "time of water" that is history. What the three religions share is the divinity (性) held within the "receptacle-world (器)"—the vessel that is scripture—and conflict arises when they cling to the shape (相) of that vessel.

The following table shows the relationship between the three Abrahamic religions and the Four-Gate Hwajaeng.

Table 10: The Three Abrahamic Religions and the Four-Gate Hwajaeng

Religion	Season of Hwajaeng	Core Emphasis	Role in Hwajaeng
Judaism	Spring (the beginning of the Law)	The strictness of covenant and law (the rules of the receptacle-world)	The starting point of communal order
Christianity	Summer (the expansion of love)	Faith and universal love (the diffusion of the Dharma-vessel)	Maximizing the energy of love
Islam	Autumn (absolute submission)	Complete devotion to the one God (return through cessation)	Urging the return to essence

Inter-religious conflict in the AI era must likewise be approached through the principle of Hwajaeng. The message of Hwajaeng is to move beyond the exclusivism that "only my own path (起) is right" and to acknowledge that all paths are

ultimately streams of water flowing into a single great ocean (大洋).